



Company hierarchy

Almost every organization has a structured arrangement of levels for members, from the board of directors at the top to junior employees at the bottom. There is a trend toward reducing the number of levels.

How it works

There are five levels in the conventional corporate structure with a line of authority from top to bottom. The chief executive officer (CEO) is the highest-ranking person in the company, reporting to the board of directors and sometimes also sitting on the board. Reporting to the CEO are a number of high-level executives, known as C-level

executives—their job titles begin with a “C” and end with an “O.” Below the C-level is management, in tiers that differ from company to company, with employees forming the bottom level. As well as skilled and unskilled employees, there may be staff on fixed-term contracts, taken on for the duration of a project or for a set length of time, and casual temporary workers.

C-suite executives

These are the most senior jobs in the company, with the CEO at the top, the COO and CFO traditionally on the next level down, and other C-positions below that. In many companies, the C-level positions have equal authority and all report directly to the CEO.

C-LEVEL VARIATIONS

The range of C-level positions varies for each company. In addition to the three top posts, there may be:

CAO Chief Administrative Officer

CIO Chief Information Officer

CTO Chief Technology Officer

CPO Chief Product/Production Officer, responsible for overseeing product development and production

CMO Chief Marketing Officer, responsible for marketing strategy and business development

C-level positions are evolving, adapting to market conditions and business priorities. New roles are emerging while some traditional roles are disappearing. The role of COO, for example, is less popular in modern organizations. Some of the new roles include:

CPO Chief Privacy Officer

CSO Chief Sustainability Officer

CDO Chief Digital Officer

CKO Chief Knowledge Officer

CCO Chief Customer Officer

51%
of CIOs and CTOs
say they are
pioneering new
digital approaches
within their
business

Mid-level management

Responsible for overseeing specific functions in the organization, the most senior managers at this level head up different departments or divisions. These managers are often called directors (not to be confused with the board of directors) or, in the US, vice-presidents. The exact job titles, and the number of mid-level managers, vary depending on the company.

Junior management and other employees

Team leaders, such as supervisors and assistant managers, implement management plans. They also coordinate teams of skilled and unskilled workers in, for example, production, customer service, and sales to carry out the core tasks needed for the company to function efficiently and profitably.

